

Joyous symmetry
Tourists at the Ranthambore National Park marvel at one of its famed residents

ALAMY

WILDLIFE MILESTONES

1865
The **first legislation on forests** and wildlife, the Indian Forest Act, enacted

1927
A **new Indian Forest Act** covers all wildlife issues, such as granting permission for hunts

1935
Forests and wildlife, a subject on the federal list, is **downgraded to the state list** under GoI Act, 1935

1968
Eight states ask the Centre for **apex legislation to govern wildlife issues**

1972
The **Wildlife Protection Act** (WPA) is passed. Hunting of animals listed in Schedule I of WPA is banned. However, provision for allowing hunting is retained

1991
An **amendment in WPA** does away with the provision to allow hunting; hunting of migratory birds also banned

1991
Felling of trees in national parks and sanctuaries banned

1991
The Indian Board for Wildlife, set up as an administrative body in 1950s, replaced with the **National Board for Wildlife**, a statutory body under the PM's chairpersonship

2003
National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) created. It is the apex decision making body for the 52 tiger reserves. Buffer zones around them made mandatory. Conservation reserves and community reserves also created.

2003
Provision to **confiscate property of those convicted** in wildlife crimes introduced in WPA 1972

44,372 sq. km
TOTAL AREA OF COUNTRY COVERED UNDER NATIONAL PARKS

that lived amongst them. Wildlife in India continued to attract hunters from all over the world, many of whom came down to 'bag' a tiger.

From the 1970s, concern was mounting across the world on environmental matters. Addressing the watershed UN Conference on Human Environment at Stockholm in 1972, then PM Indira Gandhi said India was aware of the issue but needed to tackle poverty first. The Wildlife Protection Act, 1972, passed a few months later, reiterated India's commitment towards the cause. The law imposed a ban on hunting and created national parks and sanctuaries as safe havens for wildlife. From an estimated 2,000 tigers—that majestic, mystic symbol of Indian forests—left in India in 1972, numbers are now at around 3000. ■